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COL-314201

The "Mask" Wearer

Sooner or later, a child's rebellious phase comes around, a little storm splitting a once harmonious family with lightning and thunder.

And almost every storm starts the same way, with a determination to go against the mold.

With another exorcism complete, she slips away from the bustling crowd, tucks herself away in a quiet corner, and dozes off.

Abandoned Building

While the exorcist avoids the people, she can't escape the growing hubbub as dawn comes. Cameras flash, journalists scribble, and interviewers stand in attendance.

Ramona: Huh, that's weird. The exorcism's over. Why are there still people gathering outside?

She adopted the habits of a night-shift worker at an early age, which by now has made her a full-fledged night owl. Being woken up like this is hardly unusual for her.

Ramona: *yawn* I need some more shut-eye.

Ramona: Hmm?

Two sets of footsteps echo down the dim hallway. At this hour, anyone coming here is either a ghost, or someone curious about the exorcist herself.

Judgmental Young Man: So this is where our "spectacular" exorcist neighbor, Ramona, did the ritual?

Judgmental Young Man: Figures she's a fraud. There's nothing here at all! And to think those journalists outside are calling it a miracle from some "family of exorcists"!

Judgmental Young Man: Didn't you say earlier Ramona was the real deal? You still sure about that?

Timid Young Man: But it's in the newspapers. So, there must be a reason.

Judgmental Young Man: That's some dry humor you've got there. My papá says these days, the only people who make the news are the dead and those guys in masks.

Timid Young Man: Masks ...

Judgmental Young Man: Metaphorically and literally. I heard during exorcisms they paint patterns on their faces to make them look like masks. Just some cheap theatrics.

The boys' voices grow closer. From the shadows, the exorcist hears every word clearly.

She parts her lips and quietly answers their guesses, or rather, their misunderstandings.

Ramona: False.

Timid Young Man: But, if it's all a scam, why would the city go to all this trouble to hire her? I heard they paid her a lot.

Judgmental Young Man: Truth is, it's all a publicity stunt orchestrated by City Hall. Gotta do something to get that investment money.

Judgmental Young Man: Hah, times are changing!

Ramona: Paid? First I've heard of that.

Amid the boys' chatter, a mix of irritation and betrayal pulls her thoughts back to two days earlier.

City Government Office

City Official: Señorita Ramona, are you saying you refuse to carry out this exorcism?

Ramona: You heard me. No need to ask twice.

City Official: This ritual is being held in the city's name, with even the mayor in attendance. Just think, Señorita Ramona, if this goes smoothly, you'll be a household name overnight!

Ramona's expression remains unchanged. Clearly fame and prestige are no temptation to her.

Used to bargaining in matters like these, the official quickly assumes a reason for her refusal.

City Official: Ah, I remember when I was your age, señorita. Back then, I too preferred to do things my own way.

City Official: If glory doesn't interest you, then picture this: after the ritual, the merchants will donate a substantial sum, and we'll finally be able to repair this building.

City Official: Whatever it becomes—a shopping center or a textile factory—it is sure to be a boost to the economy. What do you say?

Ramona: I'm just an exorcist. I don't know anything about the economy.

City Official: You're young. It's understandable that you don't see what businesses have done for Mexico. Just look around—railroads, public works, the power grid ... Without funding, would we have ever gotten to this point?

City Official: To be frank, we don't care who the money comes from as long as it helps us bring Mexico into the modern age!

Ramona: I get it. For this city to modernize, the ghosts've gotta be cleared out.

City Official: Exactly!

Ramona: Only problem is ...

Sensing another refusal coming, the official quickly pulls out a document.

City Official: People died there. Troublemakers. We need to make a statement. This is the exorcism contract, already signed by your parents. It's perfectly valid.

Ramona: They signed it, not me. You've got the wrong person.

City Official: I figured you'd say as much. But your parents left the country overnight for reasons we can't disclose.

City Official: It's already been announced that you'll perform the ritual. If you back out now, your family's reputation is finished.

Ramona's eyes grow even more weary, her defiance noticeably easing. Like accepting a school disciplinary notice, she takes the agreement.

Ramona: Those two cowards ...

City Official: What was that?

Ramona: Nothing. I'll be there.

Timid Young Man: Still, I heard ordinary people hire her too. To calm the spirits of dead pets and things like that.

Judgmental Young Man: That's bizarre! Our pets are Mexican too, you know. Their souls make their own way to the Sun, Mictlan, or Tlalocan, just like ours do when we die. But those frauds claim they're evil spirits and destroy them before they can even get there.

Timid Young Man: Your papá told you that?

Judgmental Young Man: Of course. He knows everything, except how rotten those phony exorcists are.

The subject of their rumors stays hidden in a corner. She shrugs them off, partly from drowsiness, partly from being used to it.

Ramona: I've heard it all before. People don't know the first thing about spirits.

Judgmental Young Man: Are you shaking?

Timid Young Man: Um, actually, I've been hearing someone talking this whole time.

Ramona: Ramona suddenly perks up.

Judgmental Young Man: Fraidy-cat. You're just imagining it.

Judgmental Young Man: Besides, there aren't any evil ghosts here!

Timid Young Man: I-I'm not sure.

Ramona: **He's right. It's not his imagination. I've been watching you.**

The voice from the darkness freezes them instantly. They turn to each other and scream, their panicked footsteps quickly echoing into obscurity.

Ramona: It was just a joke. What's all the panic for?

New footsteps sound behind her. With a sliver of curiosity, Ramona turns.

Knowing the building as well as she does, she's certain the newcomer is a living being.

A figure slowly emerges from the dark, revealing shiny dress shoes, a flared skirt, and a girl's faintly provocative stare.

???: So you really are here.

Ramona: You know me?

Her flat tone carries no sarcasm, yet somehow it irritates the other girl even more than if it did.

???: Don't play dumb. I go to St. Ignatius too. Renée, remember? We're classmates.

Ramona: I remember. You spoke to me last week.

Renée raises a brow, satisfied.

Ramona: "Stay away from me, you creep. Don't ever talk to me again." Pretty sure those were the words.

Usually the vengeful type, Renée only frowns.

Renée: Those boys just now, they your new "friends"? That's a relief. At least you're not playing with ghosts anymore.

Ramona: What do you want, Renée?

This, in truth, is why Renée dislikes Ramona. Her solitary, indifferent nature makes the social struggles of her peers feel childish.

Renée: I want your help. Whatever the mayor's paying you, I'll match it.

Ramona: I'm not getting paid for this job.

Renée: What? Why?

Ramona: Uh, "for the modernization of Mexico," or some big ideas like that.

Renée: How can you work for free? I ought to tell Mamá; she'll be sure to have plenty to say about that!

Her misplaced concern makes the moment awkward.

Renée: Ahem, don't get the wrong idea. I'm just standing up for fairness.

Ramona: Got it.

Ramona: Look, I don't get why you care all of a sudden, but you should be heading home for breakfast. Lights are up, which means I gotta sleep.

Renée: W-Wait!

But years of exorcist training have made Ramona light on her feet. She vaults the railing and vanishes without a sound, the truth behind the contract vanishing with her.

There were no ghosts in this building. The "exorcism" was nothing more than ...

... a pretentious trick.

[English text unavailable]

COL-314202

The Temptation of Happiness

Ramona's Home

On this unusually quiet morning, Ramona sets aside her agave incense and briefly returns to ordinary life. But the letters on the table nag at her like a flock of noisy chachalacas.

Making breakfast, washing dishes, sorting clothes ... She puts off opening the envelopes with any task she can. But in the end, the bright stamp stuck to the one on top wins.

As usual, inside is not only a letter, but a photograph.

She flips it over, revealing familiar handwriting and little doodles, tinged with the ambition and optimism she never inherited.

Ramona: "We've arrived in Jamaica. Unlucky for us, this ghost cat proved too tricky. If only you were here, you'd have been able to lift the curse."

Ramona: A ghost cat? What's that?

Ramona: Forget it. They probably just heard it somewhere. They can't even see ghosts.

—Which is exactly why they left right after signing the contract.

Her parents took the commission that should have been hers and trotted off to somewhere else in the world. The "exorcist family" scam continues, and the consequences fall on her once again.

After a moment, she opens another letter. The tidy handwriting and earnest advice seem to find a voice, murmuring in her ear.

Man's Voice: "It's time you started behaving better at St. Ignatius. Stop telling your teachers there are ghosts sitting on their shoulders, and don't tell your classmates the truth about what's in the restroom."

Ramona: But half the time I'm not even trying to scare them.

Woman's Voice: "Learn to refuse requests to perform exorcisms at night. It isn't good for your health."

Ramona: Most people say they're busy during the day. Even if they're scared outta their minds, they still say I gotta come after dark.

Ramona: Besides, wasn't it you who said it was money over anything?

Man's Voice: "You're older now and, of course, have every right to make your own decisions. But do you really want to live this lonely life forever?"

Ramona: It is lonely, but I don't mind it.

Man's Voice: "Others look down on you because you don't treat exorcisms as serious work. You have no friends, no home, none of the comforts of life. This is no way to live!"

Woman's Voice: "Worst of all, mi amor, you will always be thought of as a fraud. But your father and I know how honest you are. You'd rather stay silent before a spirit than say something hurtful."

Ramona: It's not honesty. I just can't talk to them. I said it a thousand times.

Ramona: And you don't have to hear a ghost to exorcise 'em anyway. It's about skills, not chatter.

Woman's Voice: "Talent is destiny, mi amor. The 'spirit sight' that never awakened in us came to you like a miracle. You must treasure it and accomplish great things."

Ramona: Destiny ... We all die eventually. If anything is predetermined, it's death.

Woman's Voice: "I know, I know, 'everyone dies eventually.' But you're only fifteen. You mustn't be so pessimistic!"

Even through the letter, they predict her answer. Blood ties.

Ramona: ...

Irritated, she crumples the letter—an action she's done so many times it's become second nature.

Ramona: You seriously telling me I gotta lie to live a good life?

Ramona: Besides, what even counts as a "good" life?

Her frustration finds no answer. And worse, she has no one to talk it out with.

She looks at the sky outside and decides to go out and find somewhere quiet.

Mexico's cities are changing quickly these days. Many people have moved into new homes, leaving some ghosts without one.

Morelos District

For nearly a week, someone has been following her. She's known for a while who it is from the footsteps alone.

And if she doesn't deal with them now, she'll never have any peace.

Ramona: I know you're there. Come out.

As usual, the haughty confidence of her stalker causes her to appear around the corner shiny-shoes-first.

Renée: You're pretty observant.

Ramona: What do you want?

Renée: I already told you. I want your help.

Ramona: Yeah, and I said no.

Renée: That's none of my concern.

The blunt reply leaves Ramona momentarily speechless. After all, conversation isn't exactly her strong suit.

Renée: Just drive the evil spirit out of my house, and I'll pay you a tidy sum. Name your price.

Ramona: ...

Renée: I may have only been at school for two months, but I already know you're capable.

Renée: Or do you care more about reputation? I can go all around the city singing your praises if you like.

Renée smooths her skirt and clears her throat, as if preparing to step onto a stage.

Renée: Come on, please, Ramona! Those evil spirits are causing such a ruckus that my papá is even planning to move us out of the city!

Renée: I simply can't leave, I can't! I've just made friends! If I leave them now, nothing but a barren, empty future awaits me!

Ramona: ...

Ramona: Isn't that a bit dramatic?

Renée: Maybe for everyday life, but for a performance it's rather good, I'd say. I think I've got it to be rather convincing, don't you?

Ramona: That's not what I meant.

Renée: Regardless, everything I said was true, especially the part about my friends. You probably wouldn't understand, ever "brave" and "independent" as you are.

Memories of her upbringing catch up to her, and she feels a little embarrassed at her own sharpness. She steadies herself. This is hardly how you ask someone for help.

Renée: Anyway, I really did come to you sincerely.

Ramona: No, I don't doubt that. It's just ... right now, people in this city are all wound up.

Ramona: It's probably just a wandering spirit that lost its way and ended up in your home. They usually leave after a few days.

Ramona: I don't think we really need to destroy them all.

Her honesty earns no trust. After all, it has never been a particularly persuasive virtue.

Renée: I hear your parents have been pulling all kinds of strings to try and make you into a famous exorcist. I can help too. You'd make a fortune.

Renée notices Ramona's eyes flicker and assumes she's reconsidering.

Ramona: This isn't going anywhere. Please, step aside, Renée.

Renée: I don't get it. Who would refuse terms like that? Do you hate me so much?

Ramona: Nah. It's just exorcisms shouldn't come tied to worldly rewards.

Ramona turns to leave again. She's always been good at avoiding problems, just like when she left home after getting that letter.

Renée: Wait!

Renée: Things at home are just awful right now. If you fix it, I'll even be your friend. I know somewhere under there you envy people like us—those of us who have someone to spend their days with.

A spoiled teen and a reclusive loner, both unaware of the sting in their words. For adolescents, this is hardly a bad thing.

Ramona turns away, letting her back give the answer.

Renée: You've not gotten rid of me! I'll be back!

In the distance, Ramona stops and turns around.

Later, Renée will often recall this moment when the understated exorcist showed a surprising softness.

Of course, Ramona herself doesn't think much at all about it.

Ramona: What was that?

Ramona: Fine. I'll deal with the spirit if you stop bothering me.

Renée: You mean ...

Ramona: Lead the way.

Ramona: And quit crying, yeah? People will think I scared a classmate again.

Renée: Right. This way!

[English text unavailable]

COL-314203

Parrot

Uptown, Mexico City

Journalist: I'm not doubting your judgment, but we've already been burned too many times by exorcists.

Journalist: It would be safer to hire one we know, or have your father's associates recommend someone.

Renée: Mamá, that's precisely what you said the last time. And do you recall how that turned out?

Journalist: Mi amor, those were just accidents. At least we've had three peaceful nights, haven't we?

The exorcist at hand stands by the door, quietly listening to their argument. Her calm refusal to argue and lack of any kind of sales pitch finally draw the mother's attention.

Journalist: Alright, Renée, you've convinced me. Now, if you'd please introduce me to your, uh, classmate.

Renée: Her name's Ramona. She handled that exorcism a few days ago—the one that both solved an urgent problem for the mayor and secured reconstruction funding.

Renée: Mamá, weren't you planning to interview her?

Journalist: What?

The look of excited surprise on her face is nothing new to Ramona. She knows exactly what thoughts are hiding behind it—reputation, prestige, the very things hinted at in her parents' letter.

Journalist: But you're just a kid. I'd expected someone older.

Ramona: Yeah, you and the rest. People usually think I'm some kind of legendary old shaman or something.

Journalist: Sorry, this spirit has caused quite the ruckus. I had to delay our interview.

Journalist: But, since you're here, perhaps we could conduct it during the exorcism? I've already prepared an outline.

A good journalist never wastes an opportunity.

Ramona: Sorry, señora, but I have to say no.

Ramona: I'm here to perform an exorcism. Nothing else.

Renée: Forget it, Mamá. She's as stubborn as a desert cactus. You'll only get pricked.

Journalist: Alright. Any journalist worth their salt knows to respect boundaries. I shan't ruin the atmosphere.

Ramona: Can I come in now?

Journalist: Of course.

Living Room

The living room is bright and tidy, but books and framed paintings lie scattered across the floor, as if a scuffle happened and the owner never had time to clean up.

In the corners the light can't reach, Ramona senses something restless, something not of this world.

Ramona: If I'd known your house had this many guests, I wouldn't have come.

Renée: Hm? But there's nobody here.

In a serious setting, dry humor always lands a moment late.

Renée: Aah! Where are they?

Ramona: Relax.

Both mother and daughter catch the note of satisfaction in the exorcist's voice at their reaction. Strangely, they don't dislike it.

In fact, it makes her seem less distant.

Ramona: Tell me what's been happening these past few days.

Renée: I thought you'd know just by looking.

Ramona: It's not that simple. Different people feel spirits differently. I need to understand how they're affecting you.

Journalist: Let me think. At first, book pages folded themselves into paper airplanes and flew around the house.

Renée: Right! At first, Mamá thought it was a surprise I'd prepared for her, until she realized they just kept flying around and around!

Ramona: A surprise?

Journalist: Yes. Renée has some arcanist blood. Her father and I always hoped her power would awaken some day.

Journalist: So, I suppose in blind hope, we were quick to misread strange things. When she scraped her knee as a child, we even encouraged her to heal it with her mind alone.

Journalist: Naive, isn't it? Like something out of a cartoon.

No one notices Ramona drift off for a moment.

Ramona: Tell me what else has been going on.

Journalist: The phonograph turns on by itself and plays music that was never recorded.

Journalist: Honestly, the songs are beautiful. If only they didn't play in the middle of the night.

Ramona: All pretty typical so far.

Renée: There's more! Marigolds sprout out of the floor every night. It's like it's the Day of the Dead every day in our house.

Renée: And glass jars keep shattering for no reason. We've got nowhere to store candy, flour, or cookies anymore.

Ramona: Sounds like the spirits really don't like you.

Renée: We didn't invite you here to insult us.

Ramona: You mentioned "three peaceful nights." Could you elaborate?

Renée: These things kept happening for a month. The only quiet nights were when an exorcist stayed awake watching over us.

Renée: Of course, she eventually left to go rest, and then everything went back to this again.

Ramona: A month? That is a pretty long time.

Ramona: Small pranks, repeated behavior, and no serious physical or mental harm. Got it.

She raises the agave incense in her hand, the ember glowing brighter and redder.

To the two clients, the laid-back air that set her apart from the city has vanished, replaced by a sharp decisiveness rare for someone her age.

Renée: Have you figured something out?

Ramona: Maybe. What did the last exorcists say?

Renée: Hmph, most of them said the only solution was some expensive warding tools, but none of them worked.

Renée: The worst was when my papá bought half a warehouse of corn kernels from a fortune-teller.

Renée: Those kernels didn't tell us anything at all! It hasn't gotten us any closer to this ghost's identity or purpose!

Ramona: Can't say it isn't creative.

Renée: I told you exorcists were all frauds!

Journalist: Oh, I'm sure Renée didn't mean to offend you, Señorita Ramona.

Ramona: Me? I didn't take it that way.

Journalist: Good. As you know, exorcists are quite popular these days, and many of your peers are sensitive to criticism.

Journalist: Public opinion matters. Especially for someone from an "exorcist family."

The journalist pauses meaningfully, her eyes locked on Ramona.

Ramona: You trying to test how I feel about this stuff, señora?

Journalist: My, you are perceptive. Sorry, habit of the profession.

Ramona: I'm not a parrot. I'm not gonna say what you wanna hear. Sorry.

The simple metaphor seems to have done its job, leaving the journalist momentarily silent.

Interpreting the awkward silence as a setback, Renée starts to grow anxious.

Renée: Mamá, you're getting off topic!

Journalist: You're right. Let's get back to the exorcism.

Ramona: To get to the point, these spirits don't care one bit about public opinion.

Ramona: And if public opinion could sway spirits, we wouldn't have so many problems.

Journalist: Hah, you're funny.

Ramona: Thanks. Not a lot of people get that about me.

Journalist: ...

Ramona: Time to get started. If you're scared, you can wait outside.

Journalist: Let's step out, Renée, for respect's sake.

Her gaze fixes on a corner of the ceiling, where several spirits drift.

The disturbances around them are violent. Not gentle ripples, but the thrashing of someone drowning.

Ramona: Not a usual state for a spirit to be in ...

She blows lightly on the agave incense. The smoke spreads, revealing the trails of the spirits to her eyes only.

Ramona: They came from outside.

Ramona: Then, are they attached to this house, or seeking revenge on the residents?

She lights a candle with the ember and releases her arcane energy through it, testing their reaction.

The spirits only grow more agitated, even trying to snuff out the flame.

Ramona: Refusing to talk, then purification it is.

Ramona: I'll send you away and end the suffering of being trapped here.

[English text unavailable]

COL-314204

By the Still Lake

Living Room

Renée: She opens the door, the bright sunlight dizzying her for a moment. The clients stand outside, anxious looks on their faces.

Ramona: You can get a good night's rest tonight.

Renée: Just tonight?

Renée: Or is that another one of your jokes?

Ramona: Spirits are complicated. I can't promise anything long-term.

Journalist: That's enough, Renée. The girl looks exhausted. Let's not trouble her any more.

Renée: ...

Renée: Ramona, would you like to join us for some dessert?

Ramona: Well ...

Journalist: Don't push yourself, dear. Exorcism must be tiring. She needs rest.

Ramona: I didn't say no.

And the clients weren't just being polite, either.

The door shuts again. This time, with Ramona as a true guest.

Journalist: Gosh, doesn't the air feel fresher?

Ramona: Not really. Probably just the lingering incense.

Renée: Want some nut brittle?

Ramona: Sure. Thanks.

Ramona: Did you just move here?

Journalist: As expected of the mayor's chosen exorcist. You're the first to ask that question. Did the spirits tell you?

Ramona: No. Renée said she just started school two months ago, and I saw the housewarming cards on your table.

Ramona: I can't actually hear ghosts speak.

Journalist: But the papers say you can communicate with them. There's all kinds of talk of people hoping to hear from their departed through you.

Ramona: That's 'cause most exorcists claim they can do that, so people go assuming I'm the same.

Ramona: While we're at it, let me clarify that spirits aren't good or evil, either. They've just lost their way in the mortal world. Once their energy runs out, they fade away on their own.

Journalist: I see. Then allow me to give a proper response.

Journalist: We bought this house two months ago. For years, Renée's father's business struggled, and we moved constantly.

Renée: Mamá, you didn't have to bring that up!

Journalist: My dear, we must be honest about our past. You can't simply avoid it because we have a better life now.

Renée: That's not what I meant.

Journalist: Señorita Ramona, I could tell the moment you arrived that Renée practically dragged you here, didn't she?

Ramona: Pretty much.

Journalist: Please forgive her. She just doesn't want to move again.

Journalist: Every move means more lost friends and another difficult beginning. I imagine you understand that.

Ramona says nothing.

To Renée, these words sound like a provocation. After all, it wasn't so long ago that she said the very same thing to try and hurt Ramona.

Renée: Mamá, why would you say that?

Journalist: Hm? Did I say something wrong?

Ramona: No.

Sensing the awkwardness, the journalist deftly changes the subject.

Journalist: By the way, about that card. It came from a partner of mine. The publishing house is running a call for essays about Mexico over the past decade.

Journalist: As a Mexicana myself, I have some thoughts I'd like to put to paper.

Journalist: I care deeply about this land, and I want my words to enter public discourse, but my own observations aren't enough. I need to learn more.

Journalist: From people like you, for example. Your silence could be a powerful entry point for an argument.

Ramona: No. I'm just not really a fan of small talk.

Renée: Mamá, stop talking about work!

For the first time, Ramona begins to understand the source of Renée's often-irritated nature.

And at the same time, Renée begins to understand why Ramona keeps to herself.

Journalist: Alright, alright, no need to get upset, Renée.

Journalist: I've got some ideas I need to jot down. I'll be in my room.

Renée: You should know, I didn't invite you just to let Mamá interrogate you.

Renée: You're just so famous these days, and she happens to be in a slump.

Ramona: I know. You wouldn't think that far ahead.

Renée: ...

Renée: You can be pretty cutting when you want to be, you know.

The herbal scent in the air fades, and the mood cools with it.

Renée: I heard you live alone while your parents travel the world. Not everyone has that kind of freedom.

Ramona: Freedom ...

Ramona: Actually, my parents are like yours, always trying to get people in on their "profound truths."

Renée: They write to you a lot, don't they?

Ramona: How'd you know that?

Ramona: Oh, right. You were following me.

Renée: I was not!

Renée: Hmph, you completely ignored me at school. So I had no choice but to come to your house!

Ramona: Did I really?

Renée: ...

Renée: What do they write about?

Renée: I'm not prying, just trying to move on to a new topic!

Ramona: They tell me to behave better at school and to cozy up with important people, that's about it.

Renée: Well, you know my mamá now, and she's a famous journalist. That ought to satisfy them.

Ramona: Yeah, as long as I don't have to be the one to tell 'em.

Renée: So they make you pursue things you're not interested in too?

Ramona: Make me? I guess. But they've eased up lately.

Renée: How did you manage that?

Ramona: It only took a few attempts at running away from home. Eventually they gave up.

Renée: That's actually a good idea.

Ramona: Renée, I should go.

Ramona: No need to pretend we're best friends, yeah?

Renée stands and glances toward her mother's study. Her sleep-deprived mind is swirling with historical events, sparing no attention for the small friendship forming in the living room.

Renée: We're settling per job, right?

Ramona: Mhm.

Renée hands the envelope of payment to her.

They're like two children playing adults. The absurdity makes Renée laugh.

Renée: I'll see you out. It's stuffy in here anyway. I want some air.

Ramona: Alright.

Ramona: But ...

She studies the girl for a moment, choosing her words carefully.

Ramona: Renée, you seem different from how you were back in school.

Renée: I'll take that as a compliment.

Uptown, Mexico City

They don't remember who first brought up the future.

Renée: If you don't want to be a famous exorcist, after graduation, my papá can find you a job.

Renée: But first you have to tell me, what do you actually want to do?

Ramona: If I could choose, I'd do something where I can be alone.

Ramona: Maybe a gravekeeper.

Renée stares at her, stunned.

Renée: You really are something.

Renée: A gravekeeper? To suppress evil spirits, I mean, ghosts?

Renée: I thought your indifference to everything but ghosts was just an act. I never thought you actually enjoyed this sort of work.

Ramona: It's just quiet.

Renée: What do you mean?

Ramona: Ghosts don't expect things from you the way people do.

Ramona: It's an honest life, one that's usually free of trouble.

Renée: Doesn't sound all that nice.

Renée: My mamá told me about a philosopher who moved to a lakeside to escape the city, but he didn't stay for long.

Ramona: Yeah. Most people prefer the hustle and bustle.

She suddenly stops walking.

Ramona: But when life becomes still, there's something pure there. It's like I'm weightless.

Renée: Really?

Renée: I only feel that way when I'm dancing. Though, dancing is rather exhausting too.

Renée: But I know what I want. I want to be a famous dancer and tour the country.

Renée: I might even send you tickets.

Ramona: Mhmm.

She doesn't take it seriously.

She doesn't think Renée will even remember her by then.

Those with exciting, busy lives don't want to hear the same ghost stories over and over again.

[English text unavailable]

COL-314205

Ghost Tricks

Morelos District

When would a normal person actually hope they had work to do?

Only when something even more troublesome than work has shown up.

She holds her breath and quickens her pace, hoping to shake off her stalker.

A task harder than any exorcism.

Renée: Ramona!

She pretends not to have heard.

Renée: Ramona, stop avoiding me, would you?!

The familiar figure steps into view. Ramona stops.

Ramona: Am I stuck in a time loop or something? This is the fourth time you've hunted me down in the last two weeks, Renée.

Ramona: You sure your family isn't hallucinating?

Renée: It's not an illusion or a hallucination or anything! The evil spirits are back!

Renée: What do they want? Are they just hell-bent on tearing flowers apart and breaking jars?

Renée: Ramona, can't you try talking to them? If they have demands, we'll do whatever we can to meet them.

Ramona: I told you before, didn't I? I can't talk to ghosts. I can only sense them.

Ramona: Forget it. Something's off.

Ramona: You haven't gone and bought any more warding tools, have you? Those often have the opposite effect.

Renée: Nope! Not a one!

Ramona: 'Cause if what you're saying is true, it sounds like you're constantly bringing them forth.

Renée: What?

Renée looks vacant. Clearly, she needs more sleep.

Renée: Mamá says if this keeps up, we'll have to move again. I don't want to lose the friends I just made.

Renée: Ramona, I know you—

Suddenly, two figures appear at the end of the alley.

Not allies, not enemies, but familiar shadows from the living world.

Judgmental Young Man: Am I seeing things, or is that Ramona?

Timid Young Man: She's not alone.

Judgmental Young Man: Señorita, you're not from this neighborhood, are you?

Judgmental Young Man: Did Ramona take control of your soul and bring you here?

Timid Young Man: She doesn't look so good.

Judgmental Young Man: Exactly. A classic sign of possession!

Their back-and-forth chatter, mixed with the sounds of the waking city, coalesces around Renée like the commotion created by those evil spirits.

But she doesn't hate the noise. Unlike Ramona, she knows enduring it is part of the life she wants to live, and she's willing to act on that.

Renée: Tsk. So childish.

She leaves Ramona's side and faces the two young men alone.

Judgmental Young Man: What was that?

Timid Young Man: She said we're childish.

Judgmental Young Man: I heard her the first time!

Timid Young Man: Oh. Sorry.

Renée: You've never actually encountered an evil spirit, have you?

Judgmental Young Man: What are you talking about? We've dealt with ghosts since we were kids. A few freaky goings-on aren't enough to spook us all the way to an exorcist's door.

Renée: Really? Because the last time you ran out of that abandoned building, you looked more scared than a pair of mice running from a kitty cat.

Judgmental Young Man: Y-You—what did you say?

Judgmental Young Man: Say something!

Timid Young Man: You're the one who told me to be quiet.

Judgmental Young Man: ...

Renée: People who have really faced spirits wouldn't waste their time mocking others.

Renée: That's why you wouldn't understand how important exorcists are to those of us still in the land of the living!

Judgmental Young Man: Huh. And here I thought you'd say something original. But it's just the same old line from the newspapers.

Judgmental Young Man: Ramona, you don't actually think she's defending you, do you? She's like the rest, just saying what you want to hear so she can use you for whatever she needs.

Judgmental Young Man: All those evil spirit stories you made up for money, they're lies!

Ramona: I never did that.

Judgmental Young Man: Your colleagues did.

Ramona: Then go wail on them.

Renée: Exactly, coward!

Judgmental Young Man: ...

Ramona: Let's go, Renée.

Renée: Huh? Where?

Ramona: Your place.

Living Room

The room feels heavy as the clients wait in silence for her answer.

Renée: Ramona, do you know the cause?

Ramona: I checked. The spirits are in the same state as before. Like the same ones came back.

Ramona: But the purification last time should've worked. Did I miss something?

Journalist: Perhaps we could try to interpret the symbolical meaning behind their behavior.

Ramona: Symbolical?

Journalist: When I write, I use symbolism to assign meaning to historical choices in a way that makes them feel almost inevitable.

Journalist: The paper airplanes they throw could symbolize social change...

Journalist: ... songs, the living, ...

Journalist: ... flowers ... I'm not sure, but perhaps returning souls.

Journalist: The only thing still troubling me is the shattering candy jars.

Journalist: Could they represent gunshots rupturing through the past?

Ramona shakes her head.

Ramona: No, señora. Some things are easier for spirits.

Ramona: It'll only mix you up to keep interpreting things like that.

Renée: Perhaps Papá was cursed by a business rival? Some kind of black magic?

A tear rolls down Renée's cheek.

Journalist: Don't worry, dear. Señorita Ramona will handle it.

Journalist: Apologies. She's been unusually sensitive lately.

Ramona: Sensitive?

Journalist: Likely just adolescence. At her age, emotions are unpredictable.

Journalist: She's been ever so restless, emotions all over the place.

Adolescence? Emotions?

The words strike her with a sudden insight, untangling the knot in her thoughts.

She's lived alone so long that she forgot to consider emotions when dealing with spirits.

Ramona: Señora, take Renée to the bedroom.

Ramona: I'll handle this.

[English text unavailable]

COL-314206

Summoning Spring

Living Room

The purification proceeds smoothly. The lost spirits depart once more, the corners clear, and the smoke trails settle.

Ramona: She shakes the incense stick. The ember dims, leaving only fragrance.

Ramona: It's done.

Journalist: It took you longer than last time.

Ramona: Yeah. Was trying to understand why they keep coming back, but I came up with nothing.

Journalist: Señorita Ramona, I'm confused.

Ramona: What?

Journalist: The papers say you can intimidate and control spirits through arcane skills. Some even claim you can train them if you so desire.

Journalist: But watching you, I see that you approach things with caution, not with the kind of power they describe.

Journalist: Are the papers exaggerating, or are you hiding your strength?

Ramona wants to avoid the question until she catches Renée's searching gaze.

She has never told anyone this secret.

Because of it, she has endured troubles both internal and external.

But she can't keep running forever. Perhaps this is the moment to begin.

Ramona: Actually ...

Ramona: Those are lies told by my parents.

Ramona: I can't control spirits. All I've got is a little talent for sensing and purifying them.

Renée: What?

She feels the mother's and daughter's shock, and the twinkle of excitement in the journalist's eyes. An excitement that burns.

Ramona: That's the truth of it. My parents are con artists. The "exorcist family," the "special bloodline," my fame—it's all marketing.

Ramona: They played you all for fools. Some people even defend them.

Journalist: Yet you refused to cooperate with their lie. After that exorcism, many called you a fraud.

Journalist: There was no trace of purification in the building. It just looked like any other abandoned place. The crowd quickly lost interest.

Journalist: If there's no flash, no pizzazz, then things disappear from the public eye in an instant.

Journalist: I heard one investor even withdrew funding.

Ramona: I know. But, truth is, there were no spirits in that building. And I'm not a liar.

Renée: You mean you intentionally left no evidence so that people would expose you?

Ramona: ...

As usual, she stays silent. She never meant it as an act of noble resistance. She just followed her conscience.

Journalist: I always thought there was something profound behind your silence. I suppose it turns out the reason was simple.

Ramona: Like I said, things really aren't that complicated in this city.

Ramona: And the truth can be found in things other than words.

Journalist: Interesting perspective. I should write that down.

Renée: No! Mamá, she never lied to us. And this is a private conversation.

Journalist: Mm, alright.

Journalist: Forgive my eagerness. Let's go back to talking about the spirits.

Ramona: That's what I was thinking too.

Ramona: Hey, at least you're more open-minded than I thought.

Ramona: Just, please, don't go publishing our chat in the paper.

Journalist: So in the eyes of a teenager, I'm not completely beyond hope after all?

Ramona relaxes.

Ramona: Like I said before, spirits aren't inherently good or evil. They're drawn back to the living world by certain things, for example—

Ramona: Family.

Renée: What do you mean? Are you saying those spirits are our ancestors?

Journalist: But, they're not buried anywhere near here.

Renée: Perhaps ghosts don't follow the rules of the physical world?

Ramona: It's not about the ghosts. It's about you, Renée.

Renée: Two pairs of eyes turn to Renée, and she suddenly feels an inexplicable fear.

The fear of being seized, of being erased.

A fear that is not her own, and she has to hide it.

Ramona: Renée, if I've got it right, some kind of arcane power has awakened in you.

Renée: What?

Ramona: Your arcane energy draws spirits to you. Far as I can tell, one of your ancestors belonged to an ancient "House of Song" or was an Aztec priest, maybe.

Ramona: That's why you love to dance the Jarabe Tapatío. In older times, dance was a way to communicate with spirits and gods.

Renée: Ramona, you're not pulling my leg, are you?

Ramona: If I'm right, there's a spirit residing within you at this very moment.

Ramona: Not a common thing. Ghost stories call it possession. That's why your personality's changed.

Renée: Stop! I'm getting goosebumps.

Ramona: I'm not trying to scare you. This is the first time I've seen it too.

Ramona: It was drawn to you and merged with your body. Revitalized, in a way, letting it completely mask its presence.

Ramona: That's what's been calling the other spirits here again and again.

Ramona: Renée, those repeated destructive acts, they remind you of anything?

Renée: No ...

Ramona: Or maybe I should call you "ghost," yeah?

She raises the incense stick and, for the first time, chants toward a living person.

Ramona: Ilusiones, apartaos. La verdad se revela.

Renée: No!

Journalist: Renée!

"She" awakens.

The arcanum in the host's bloodline is too weak for "her" to even see clearly.

"She" makes out only scattered lights and two shadows, instinctively knowing they're two living people.

Someone speaks near "her," but "she" cannot hear the words.

Journalist: Renée, Renée!

Journalist: Thank goodness, you're awake!

Journalist: Señorita Ramona, wh-why isn't she saying anything?

Ramona: It's confused. It needs guidance before it can leave.

A calming fragrance reaches "her," soothing the stabbing pain of her memories.

A hand rests on "her" forehead—dry, warm—and the burning sensation fades.

Ramona: Este lugar, este instante. Revelado ante mí. Mostrado para mí.

"She" hears the incantation like a ringing bell. The scent of flowers drifts in the breeze, and "she" feels the warmth of a spring afternoon.

In "her" memory, "she" was sick, feverish. A doctor's white coat swayed before "her" eyes. A familiar figure entered the bedroom carrying flowers.

Who is that?

Journalist: She's shaking.

Journalist: Is the evil spirit hurting her?

Journalist: Is it attacking her soul?

Ramona: No, the spirit's lingering consciousness is affecting her body.

Ramona: Renée's reaction is so strong because ...

Ramona: ... that fragment of awareness carries powerful emotion.

"She" feels surrounded by fragrant smoke, like a warm embrace.

"She" remembers. The one who brought flowers was "her" father. He was always busy then, rarely able to stay by "her" side.

The bouquet is set beside the bed, the crumpled wrapping making a sound like rain.

That long-suppressed longing tries to burst into words, but the sounds jam in her throat, and her body trembles.

Journalist: What's happening?! Renée! Renée!

Ramona: I ... I don't know what it wants to say.

She cannot see or hear it clearly. She has no way to answer the feeling.

And "she," trapped in silence, cannot speak.

[English text unavailable]

COL-314207

Together Forever

Bedroom

The smoke around Renée slowly stabilizes, at least proving the possessing spirit means no harm.

Having finished her desperate phone call, the journalist pushes the door open.

Journalist: Any progress, Señorita Ramona?

Ramona: Nope. Until I know its identity, I can only calm it.

Journalist: I just spoke to an exorcist I know. She said you can erase it with a purification circle.

Ramona: Yeah, if it was a regular spirit.

Ramona: But this one's emotions are intense. They're already affecting Renée's mind.

Ramona: Forcibly separating it from her might give her psychological trauma.

Journalist: Is there another way?

Ramona: There is.

Journalist: Then why aren't you doing it?

Ramona: ...

Journalist: S-Sorry.

Ramona: We need to identify it first. Then I'll guide it to the land of the dead through the ritual.

Journalist: The land of the dead? You've seen it?

Ramona: Nah, not seen it. But during exorcisms, I can faintly sense it.

Ramona: Spirits that remember who they are feel ... relieved when they depart.

Ramona: Those that forget struggle. Their pain causes way more trouble. Damage too.

Journalist: I see. I understand your concern now.

Journalist: So, what can we do?

Ramona: If you don't mind, I want it, uh, "Renée," to summon the ghosts again.

Ramona: I may not be able to hear them, but they can sure communicate with each other.

Ramona: From the way they gather, I can figure out their relationship.

Journalist: ...

Journalist: Alright. I suppose I don't have much choice but to trust you.

Ramona: I'll need your help too, señora.

Journalist: Of course. This is about my daughter.

Ramona: Do you know who owned this house before you?

Journalist: I can find out. I'll contact the agent who sold it to us.

Ramona looks at Renée. Her client, and now the very thing she must purify.

Having confirmed that the possessing spirit cannot speak through this body, she knows that the limits of her ability aren't the reason for this silence.

Ramona: Still, I wanna know what "you" are trying to "say."

She crushes the incense ash and sketches a circle on the floor.

Not for purification, but for summoning. For someone who can't hear spirits, it's risky.

Ramona: Verdad revelada, disfraces disipados.

Outside, insects continue to chirp.

A deep nostalgia swells inside "her," as if this ordinary day belongs to a distant past.

Ramona: The resonance is stronger.

"She" cannot leave the house, not with this illness bringing "her" dizziness and nausea.

"She" feels lost. "She" wants to call "her" father. Like always.

A patient with only enough strength to ring a bell.

A song suddenly echoes through the living room, mournful and familiar.

Ramona: They're back.

A gust of wind scatters the ash, sending Ramona stumbling back. The banished ghosts have returned.

Petals and paper airplanes swirl, and glass trembles like ice under too much weight.

Ramona senses the spirit floating in the ceiling corner, quietly watching. It's somewhat weaker than before.

Ramona: At least it's not aggressive.

The mother rushes in with new information, this time unconcerned with the state of the room.

Journalist: I found out. The former owner was a businessman by the name of Juan López. He got in financial trouble and sold the house seven years ago.

Journalist: My colleague from the press found an article about him. He later moved to the Morelos District.

Journalist: He committed suicide five years ago.

An idea flashes across her mind. There are many coincidences in this world, and it takes an exorcist to read inevitability within coincidence.

Journalist: Is he the one possessing Renée?

Ramona: Nah, it's not him.

The hymn carries the blessings of ancestors, wishing "her" a speedy recovery.

"Her" spirit rides a paper airplane, leaving Mexico City—across northern plains, southern mountains, and over the ocean to the far side of the world.

The game of smashing candy jars that ran through "her" childhood, the flowers laid out to look like the sun every Day of the Dead ... "She" liked these things.

"She" once forgot those joys, and the forgetting made "her" weaker, so her father spared no expense bringing "her" music, flowers, and games.

Ramona: Señora, did Señor López have family?

Journalist: I don't know. The coverage in the news was just a single line!

Ramona: But we need more if I'm gonna crack this.

Ramona: Don't these "pranks" feel like something parents would do to try to cheer up a kid?

Like the letters and photos Ramona's parents keep sending her.

Journalist: What ...

Ramona: If the two converging concentrations of pneuma I feel aren't fighting each other, then there's only one possibility.

Ramona: The one attached to Renée is Señor López's child.

Ramona: She missed her father so much she called him back to the land of the living.

Journalist: Incredible. Señorita Ramona, why are you crying?

Ramona: It's just a disturbance in the pneuma.

Ramona: The school ... Señora, with your connections, it shouldn't be hard to find a student list from seven years ago, right?

Ramona: There weren't a lot of girls' schools in Mexico City then.

Journalist: I can do that.

Ramona: I'll wait for your news. Find out as soon as possible, yeah? Renée can't stay like this for long.

The mother rushes out of the room.

The circle on the floor is already distorted, and the forcibly summoned spirit has nearly exhausted its energy.

Ramona: Thank you for not hurting Renée.

The girl sees "her" father turn transparent again, leaving to repay debts, compete with foreign merchants, and keep a failing business alive.

"She" is too young. "She" holds nothing but longing.

No ... no ... no!

"She" doesn't want to stay here anymore, doesn't want to endure this loneliness!

Ramona: Just hang in there.

She blows on the incense stick, sparks flashing as she pushes herself to keep the pneuma stable.

Journalist: Found it!

Journalist: Her name is Bonita. She left school due to an illness.

Ramona: Bonita ...

Ramona: That's a nice name.

She presses her hand to Renée's forehead again.

Ramona: Las mentiras se desvanecen; la verdad se desvela.

"She" hears another incantation. Shorter than before, but it seems to make "her" sight clearer.

This place is new, not "her" old room.

A strange fragrance fills the air, and a gentle, unfamiliar girl's face comes into view, a look of pity on her face.

Paper airplanes glide, flowers whirl, and glass shatters.

They lead her memory across a bridge, welcoming "her" arrival.

And in the low rushing wind, "she" remembers "her" death.

Ramona: It's time to go, Bonita.

[English text unavailable]

COL-314208

A New Life for Us

Living Room

Another warm invitation.

But this time the exorcist hasn't come for work.

Journalist: We truly owe you for what you did, Señorita Ramona.

Journalist: You really put into perspective how precious even an ordinary life is.

Ramona: You already paid my fee. You didn't need to invite me over.

Journalist: Haha, you haven't changed a bit.

Journalist: Renée's fully recovered. She wanted to thank you in person.

Renée: Mamá, don't exaggerate!

Her classmate has returned to her overconfident self again.

Ramona: Still hearing ghosts in your head, Renée?

Renée: What?! Is that another one of your jokes or something?

Renée: Well, don't even think about trying to scare me! An arcanist doctor my papá knows examined me. I won't be attracting any more ghosts.

There isn't even a hint of uncertainty in her voice.

Journalist: Yes, Renée is much better suited to dancing.

Renée: Ramona, I heard you turned down Señor Javier's request. He was offering a lot of money.

Ramona: Yeah. Don't want the attention. Besides, I'm not the only exorcist who can purify the spirits in his place.

Renée: That's all very well, but if you keep hiding like this, one day everyone in Mexico City will forget you.

Ramona: Sounds perfect.

Renée: You ...

Journalist: Now, now, Renée. We didn't invite Señorita Ramona here to rile her up. Give her the gift you prepared.

Ramona: Gift?

Renée: It's not a gift! It's the payment I promised you—the rest of it, I mean.

A property transfer contract rests in the folder, with a key beside it.

Ramona: You've already paid me what you owed. The work I did isn't worth anything extra.

Renée: You're being stubborn.

Renée: Mamá said you collapsed from exhaustion after helping me. So, please, take it. It's yours already.

Renée: We argued for ages about what you'd like. Finally, we settled on a remote cemetery.

Renée: The seller looked like he'd seen a ghost when we told him we wanted it!

Renée: Too bad the ghost in me is gone now! Heh heh.

Ramona: Nice one, Renée.

Renée: Ahem. Anyway, there'll be no one to bother you there. You can avoid your lying parents and live quietly and honestly, just as you wish.

Renée: It's already decided, so just take it, alright? Otherwise I'll come to your house myself, and—

Ramona: Alright, alright. I'll accept it. Thank you, Renée.

Renée: Stop that. We're not friends, you got that?

She takes the folder, and, with it, steps into her future.

Uptown, Mexico City

Journalist: Before you leave, there's something I need to tell you.

Ramona: What?

Journalist: I'm not going to finish writing this book.

Ramona: Why?

Journalist: It's embarrassing to admit, but when I was writing it, I focused entirely on imagery and metaphors.

Journalist: It's as though I lost my passion for pursuing the truth.

Journalist: I feel ashamed, really, at my insincerity.

Journalist: There's still much about Mexico City I don't understand, just like how you can't hear spirits.

Journalist: And you were right. Once I stopped listening to the noise outside, I finally saw what was hidden underneath.

Ramona: I understand.

Ramona: Just don't do it with regrets, yeah? Like Renée doesn't regret losing her arcane skill.

Journalist: You're right. I have a lot to learn from you and Renée about being at peace with myself.

Journalist: Adiós.

Ramona: Adiós, señora.

Cemetery

On yet another Day of the Dead, Ramona arrives at her future home with candles and flowers in hand.

She is making preparations to move in soon.

The names and epitaphs on the tombstones are worn by time but still readable.

The spirits drifting here have long been forgotten, unable to pass on.

But it's not too late. Some still remain, not yet lost to pain and despair.

She arranges the candles and flowers, setting up a small altar.

Ramona: I'll remember you.

Ramona: And Señor López, and Bonita.

Ramona: You'll return to this world again, with new lives.

With her preparations complete, she begins guiding the souls onward.

Ramona: ¡Abraza la luz... hacia las tierras más allá de la muerte!

The flames flare in an instant, and petals lift into the wind, rising toward the night's sky.

Her rebellious phase came early, forcing her to face the questions of who she was and what kind of life she wanted.

During the long period of solitude, she neither retreated to a lonely lakeside like a philosopher nor immersed herself in a bustling city like a performer.

She simply drifted, like a ghost.

But in the end, she made her choice.

Ramona: You either live among the living, or live among the dead.

Ramona: From now on, this is my "good life."

An officer in a black uniform arrives to inspect the Vigiles Bureau's new contractor. Unfortunately for her, there isn't even a spare chair for her to sit in yet.

Black Ibis: I ought to bring you a housewarming gift, Ms. Ramona. Say a chair and table?

Ramona: Thanks, but no thanks. I only just left the clutter of my "psychic family." I'm good without any more stuff.

Ramona: Think of it as running away from home. But indefinitely.

She calmly continues organizing her few belongings. The officer, quickly giving up on inviting her to the office, leans on the doorway instead.

Black Ibis: Alright, let's get to the point.

Black Ibis: Ms. Ramona, you've handled a great deal of arcane disturbances with impressive results.

Black Ibis: In fact, I hear that even the most influential figures in Mexico City come to you in hopes of uncovering the secrets of the night.

Black Ibis: With skills like that, there was no need to list your "defect" in your file.

Ramona: I was just being honest, boss.

She pauses and looks seriously at her superior.

Ramona: Do the Vigiles have a problem with the fact that I can't hear spirits talk?

Ramona: Are you trying to fire me?

Black Ibis: Oh, nothing like that. This is just a follow-up visit. I'm new to the branch, so I need to understand my future partners.

Ramona studies her superior for a moment. Satisfied, she resolves to trust her.

Ramona: Actually, I don't think of it as a defect.

Ramona: Different exorcists have different methods. For me, not hearing spirits is an advantage.

Ramona: Just like the living, the dead lie too. I've heard of many exorcists being misled by what spirits say.

Ramona: But living or dead, the traces they leave behind always lean toward truth.

Ramona: And with that, I can uncover those fabricated secrets and truths buried by time.

Black Ibis: Impressive. It's no wonder the city's elites want to meet you.

Black Ibis: Your skills are exactly what the Vigiles need.

She closes her folder, signaling the end of the inspection.

Ramona: That's it?

Black Ibis: You've made yourself perfectly clear. No need for me to pretend to take notes.

Ramona: Wait, boss. I have a request.

Black Ibis: I'm listening.

Ramona: I'd like to keep some secrets of my own, if you don't mind.

Ramona: So if you send people to find me, they gotta go through some steps first. Exorcist stuff.

Black Ibis: What steps?

Ramona: Two steps. First, spin around ten times with your arm out like an elephant's trunk. Then, whistle the tune of *La Llorona*. I'll come out.

Black Ibis: Is there some deeper meaning to that? I mean, in exorcism terms.

Ramona: No. I just made it up.

Black Ibis: So you don't want to be disturbed.

Black Ibis: Haha, understood.

As they talk, Ramona gathers a thick stack of letters and tosses them straight into the fire.

Black Ibis: Letters from a friend? Had a falling out?

Ramona: Friend? They're from my parents.

Black Ibis: Your parents? I see. Then, I'll treat this as another one of your secrets.

Ramona: Appreciate it, boss.

Ramona: If it's not too much trouble for you, I'll just use the Bureau's address from now on. The mailman can deliver them there. I won't read them anyway.

Black Ibis: Sure. Once you officially join, you'll have a desk and a mailbox.

Ramona: That's the real reason you came here today, isn't it?

Black Ibis: You got me. Wouldn't want to miss out on new talent.

Ramona: I don't like the idea of being a Vigil.

Ramona: A contractor's life is just right for me. Low commitment. Besides, I've never been good at dealing with beings that talk.

Black Ibis: Fair enough. The Bureau can develop a partnership model as well.

Ramona: Thanks for understanding, boss. I gotta go. There's a job waiting.

Black Ibis: Adiós, Ramona.

Ramona: Adiós, boss.